My First “Dear Jon” Letter

Evan Weiss

Dear John letter
noun
us /ˌdɪr ˈdʒɑːn ˌleṭ.ɚ/ uk /ˌdɪə ˈdʒɒn ˌlet.ər/
(also Dear John)

1. a letter written to end a romantic relationship.
2. a letter (as to a soldier) in which a spouse or partner asks for a divorce or a partner breaks off an engagement or a friendship

Dear Jon letter
noun
us /ˌdɪr ˈdʒɑːn ˌleṭ.ɚ/ uk /ˌdɪə ˈdʒɒn ˌlet.ər/
(also Dear Jon)

1. a fictional letter written by a character named Evan Weiss to the novelist Jonathan Franzen in which the former presents occasionally embellished autobiographical details and various insights related to literature, politics, psychology, fashion, and culture in an effort to secure the latter’s friendship.
2. a letter addressed to a person named Jon, either real or fictional, in which the author ironically alters the connotation of the salutation “Dear John” by requesting John’s or Jon’s friendship.
3. a creative writing assignment submitted by a student named Evan Weiss to Dr. Nathan Oates in partial fulfillment of the requirements of a graduate level creative writing seminar titled Innovative Fiction in which Evan hopes to demonstrate sufficient aptitude in the uses of both fiction and literary criticism to obtain a very good grade in the course.
September 20, 2025

Dear Jon(athan Franzen),

I KNOW you've gotten that one before, but I just couldn't resist 🙂. And yes, if by some weird chance this gets published in my school's graduate literary journal as an example of "experimental fiction," I'll probably title it *My First Dear Jon Letter*, only because that would be ironic (and thus literary) seeing as how this is the opposite of a breakup letter. Which leads me to why I'm writing to you in the first place, Mr. Franzen, or Jon, which is that I'd like to propose that we become friends. As crazy as it sounds, I mean an *actual* friendship, one in which we write to each other occasionally (maybe even often 😑) about our personal and professional lives, either via handwritten letters or e-mail messages, you know, in the old school "epistolary" way, like they say. I'm not so delusional as to believe we'll ever meet in person, but a Zoom or Google Meet once in a blue moon isn't out of the question imo.

This kind of thing isn't totally unheard of either. I just read a book called *84, Charing Cross Road*. You've probably heard of it, or at least know the backstory. It's a slim lil memoir by a mediocre playwright who's looking for some British classics and so she writes a letter to a bookstore in England requesting a catalog or a few specific titles, I can't remember which, and the owner of the bookstore receives her letters directly and admires the writer's knowledge of books so much, and vice versa, that they end up writing back and forth to each other for YEARS, actually until the bookstore owner dies. Admittedly, I read the book because it was short and I had to pad my Goodreads stats for whatever year that was. (By the way, I'm so curious what your Goodreads numbers are. My best year was 2018: 38 books💪). But I thought they had a really good thing going on between them, this lady and her bookseller, something I'm lacking in my own life. I'm no bookseller, but I do hope to prove myself useful and interesting in similar ways to this British guy.

I'm sure you think I'm Stan-ing after reading one of your novels, but it's not like that at all. As I always say, a true friendship should be built from the very beginning on radical honesty, so I'll admit now that I haven't actually read any of your fiction. (For what it's worth, though, I have lied about this fact to a few Tinder dates who mentioned you by name in their bios). The one thing I did read of your's, the whole reason why I'm writing this letter actually, is the essay you wrote for *The New Yorker* in 2001 called "Mr. Difficult." I read it a few weeks ago. It was assigned to me by my creative writing teacher, who's a writer too. We talked about it in class, and if I'm being honest with you, as I've promised to be, some of my classmates expressed very negative opinions of you. They called you a snob and insufferable, and one of them made the kinda clever joke that your fourth novel, *Freedom*, should've been called *Free-dumb*. I promise I took your side. I'll get to the literary merits of your argument and why I agree with them soon, but the first thing I thought was that you and I have *so much* in common.

Like the stuff about your mom and dad. Totally relatable. My dad was the smart one too. He has a doctorate in education, which he got "via correspondence" (i.e. through the mail) from a school that doesn't exist anymore called the University of Sarasota. He actually plagiarized his dissertation, and if you write me back I'll tell you how I know 😉. When people ask about him, like my therapist does sometimes, I describe him as "a Woody Allen-esque New York Jew without the film and literary knowledge." I just wanna pause here and acknowledge that I feel very comfortable talking to you like this – in these really simple metaphors and allusions, I

mean. Like, I don't know, I just trust that when I say my dad is "Woody Allen-esque without the film and literary knowledge" you'll smile and then imagine someone who nebbishly complains about his crowded subway car but doesn't have the references to compare it to Sartre's version of hell in *No Exit*. Or if you don't know who Woody Allen is, which I doubt because he's very famous, you could always ask somebody or look him up on Wikipedia and then you'll understand my meaning. And once you do, it'll be like we came up with this meaning together, with me doing most of the work but you participating too!

Maybe I have this trust in you because of what you wrote in your essay about novels being a "compact between the writer and reader" and how the whole purpose of them is to "sustain a sense of connectedness." There's so many writers who don't view writing this way, who think it's clever and transgressive and more "realistic" to confuse the reader, like this William Gaddis whose book made you angry. What you said about his novel *J.R.* reminded me of this philosopher duo I read about in Introduction to Lit Theory with Dr. Sherman. Their names were Deleuze and Guttari. More like **DELULU** and Guttari if you ask me though 😂😂😂, because they made their bones on this silly theory that reality is totally random and not "hierarchical," and so our experiences can't add up to any bigger ideas or truths, which means we can't put things into categories or say that one thing is like another thing so that people can understand what we mean better because if we do this we're basically creating a fake world above our real world. In other words, they'd take issue with me calling my father Woody Allen-esque because to do so would be to mYsTiFy tHe cOnDiTiOns oF mY dAd's mAtErIaL eXiStEnCe. I dunno man. I'm getting tired, and in a few minutes I'm gonna pop a ~~Percocet~~ Melatonin and hit the sack. But before I go to bed I just want to clarify that what I'm trying to say in those last few sentences is this: metaphors, the good and easy and friendly ones anyway, are like inside jokes. They're not always funny, but sometimes they are, and they always make you feel connected to the other person who's inside of it with you. Maybe it's because of how lonely I feel sometimes that I love a good inside joke. I have exactly one friend at work, a girl about my age named Carmen, and the other day we were sitting in a staff meeting when our boss did the very thing that we make fun of behind his back. He said the phrase "coming down the pipes" (it's supposed to be "coming down the pike"), and we both shot each other a glance and exchanged the same barely noticeable smirk. I know it seems like such a small experience to share with another person, but how do I tell you that in that moment I felt like she was all I needed to be whole in this world?

•

Yerrrrr. Jon, I'm back. I slept well last night, as I have been more or less since the EMDR. Even when I'm well-rested I still end up on the couch (or sometimes the floor if my laundry is folded on the couch) for like an hour or so in the morning, which makes me late for work a lot of the time, but in the moment it feels very urgent and essential for me to be there, on the couch or floor I mean, not sleeping but also not thinking about anything in particular. Sometimes I'll put a podcast on and close my eyes without dozing off, and then before I know it this force, not entirely inside of me but not outside of me either, if that makes any sense, just kind of propels my body upward and onward. But while I was couching today, the thought of you lying on your own couch popped into my mind. Not on no Diddy shit or anything like that, Jon. I think what happened was that I had just read "Mr. Difficult" and being on the couch myself reminded me of

the passage in that essay where you describe the "beige ultrasuede sofa module" where you read *The Recognitions* for 6 to 8 hours a day. Only I didn't envision you reading *The Recognitions*, because I've never read that book and don't even know what the cover looks like. In my vision you were holding a paperback copy of *Moby Dick*, because of all those books that you said you never could finish in "Mr. Difficult," that's the only one I've tried to read myself. And then what happened was I headed over to my laptop and got back to writing this letter, this friendship offering really, because this vision of you in my head reminded me of something else we have in common, which is that we both wanted to stop reading *Moby Dick* after a couple of pages. To be sure, I *did* read the whole thing, basically because I had to for Dr. Sbriglia's class. But if there were more than 6 kids in that class and I could've gotten away with stopping at, say, page 60 and not having to comment on the chapters about whale semen and floating coffins and Pip wylin' out, I absolutely would have. Because all the power of that book lies in the first paragraph. And it really *does* cease to matter all that much after the main guy, Ishmael, who's meant to be just like you and me, decides to "sail about a little," and that happens in, what?, like the second sentence?

Sorry; I just re-read those first few lines of *Moby* and got so worked up that I needed a paragraph break. Do you see what I mean tho? It's like in just a few beats, no more than 6 or 7 sentences, Melville gets at what I've been trying to tell these VA shrinks for the last 6 or 7 years: THAT IT'S NOT JUST DEPRESSION. And sure, if you read that first paragraph quickly, which a lotta people do because you've got 396 more pages to go after it, you'll get the sense that Ishmael's just sad and bored and that *that's* why he goes to sea, maybe to be around new people and stay busy, and even ChatGPT believes that's what motivates him: "depression and the monotony of land life" is what they say. It's probably because that phrase "the damp, drizzly November in my soul" sticks out so much that people think this way about Ishmael. I admit it's a really good and friendly metaphor for depression, esp. if you've been to New York in November without your Triple Fat Goose (or your thrifted Levis chore coat for my Bushwick heads). But once you've read that whole paragraph a couple of times, the lines that really slap, even more than Ishmael's drizzly soul, are when he says he needs to "drive off the spleen," which the footnote claims is about controlling his "irritation," and also when he talks about needing to leave Manhattan or else he'll run out into the street and start "knocking people's hats off." I don't know about you, Jon, but I feel this way a lotta the time, like a couple of times a day at least. I'm not talking about knocking people's hats off per se, I'm not much of a physical person, but just that impulse to put my body into some kind of motion for no good reason other than that it's fuckin' impossible to stay still. What I'm saying by all of this is that you don't run out into the street and knock someone's hat off because you're sad and don't want to go on anymore; it's more like you do it because the inertia is unbearable but that energy still has to go SOMEWHERE.

And tbh, I envy Ishmael in the worst way, because at least he has SOMEWHERE to go. Think about it: we have all these planes, trains, and automobiles, but we can't really *go* anywhere. And by "go" I don't mean take a trip, which of course we can do once in a while, albeit for short periods of time before we have to rush back to work, no, I'm talkin' "go" as in radically change our lives like Ishmael does when our own spleens start to bubble up. When you really consider it, all we ever do is "grab a drink" or "get some coffee" or play pickleball or goon out on OnlyFans. *There's no more sea*. *There's no more West*. *There's no more wilderness*. I don't mean these things don't exist physically, they obviously do, even though they're technically covered by

phone towers and WiFi and aren't remote anymore. What I mean is that we've built up these big "bourgeois" forcefields all around ourselves to make sure we never leave our clustered duplexes and buildings and families and jobs and communities … and also to make sure that we can't act when we start to get those jitters, at least not in any meaningful or actually transformative way. I put "bourgeois" in quotes right there because it's not really my word. Well, it's not really anybody's word, but for the purpose of explaining why we have to goon out on the Hub instead of running away like Ishmael, I got that word, and really the whole idea of us being trapped, from Dr. Sherman. (I realize I mentioned Dr. Sherman earlier but didn't tell you who he is. He teaches Shakespeare here at Seton Hall. Very nice man. Very smart. Owns a plethora of earthy and blue-gray oxfords and plaids, which may seem like an irrelevant fact at the moment, but it'll matter when I finally muster up the courage to give you some awkward advice that I've been sitting on since I started this letter, which maybe I'll do after I stuff this ~~Xany~~ Melatonin I saved up). Anyway, one time in class Dr. Sherman was saying that *Hamlet* is still popular because modern performances of *Hamlet* make us think about our "bourgeois subjectivity," and I didn't know what "bourgeois subjectivity" meant so I asked Dr. Sherman to define that phrase and he said "maybe think of it as 'basic middle class values'," and then it all made sense why contemporary people enjoy hearing Hamlet speak. He's essentially this upper middle class guy who has all of these yearnings and complicated thoughts but can't live them out or even express them to anyone but the audience because he belongs to a family and a community and a government and also because he's actual *royalty*, so to do what his mind and body are urging him towards would be totally prohibited or just really shameful.

I saw a modern *Hamlet* once. It was at the Park Avenue Armory (which is a shitty place to see a play if you're with a Tinderella, because it's on the UES-ish and its surrounded by expensive bars and restaurants so you've gotta make up a reason to take her waaaaay Uptown or back near Penn Station for dinner afterwards or else you'll end up eating at The Monkey Bar or Wolfgang's, which YOU can probably afford but I can't). Anyway, modern *Hamlet*. Yeah, so in this version of *Hamlet*, the director, Robert Icke I think?, puts everyone in clothes that we'd wear today – basically tight-fitting sequin dresses for the gurls and quarter zips and black Hugo Boss suits for the bois – all to put us in the frame of mind that this is happening today. And more importantly, the ending is modern too, because instead of dying from his stab wound after telling Horatio to share his story, Hamlet goes into a dream-like state where he sees all of his close friends and family members kibitzing happily at a soiree. They're behind a huge glass wall with a sliding glass door and they're drinking martinis and there's a DJ, and then there's Hamlet, wounded, crawling up to the door. He tries to open it but he can't because it's locked, and then he tries to get someone's attention by banging on the glass door and either they can't see or hear him or they refuse to, probably the latter because it *is* a thin glass wall (I mean, I know they can hear him because I can hear my neighbor screaming expletives into the Call of Duty chat even through multiple layers of sheet rock). And then, realizing he'll never get in again, Hamlet dies right there outside of the party. I'm saying that this is modern not just because they're drinking espresso martinis, which to my knowledge didn't exist during the Elizabethan period, but because the director is definitely putting Hamlet's death – *the fact that he's literally bleeding out on stage* – on the same level as his expulsion from all of the Bourgeois circles that make up his life, as if one is just as bad as the other. You're gonna think this is crazy, but you know who reminds me of this version of Hamlet? Chip from your book *The Corrections*, which I told you I didn't read, which was true when I said it but isn't anymore because I downloaded a free sample

(just the first 60 pages) and read it before the ~~Percocet~~ Melatonin kicked in last night. Amirite, tho? Chip definitely wants to fuck Melissa Paquette, the student who plops down on the couch in his office and puts her feet on his lap seductively. I mean he's got those jitters and that's what his body's urging him to do, and the only reason he doesn't at first is because he's a "good boy" from a "good family" and also he's an ideologue who teaches critical theory at a big university so he has to seem morally scrupulous to others, but also to himself, kinda like how Hamlet wants to avenge his father but doesn't because he still sees himself as the happy toddler who took piggy back rides from Yorick. Buuuuuut, eventually, those jitters, that unexplainable desire to put his body into motion, kinda like that thing I was telling you about earlier that feels like its coming from both within and beyond your body, it just takes over and Chip gives in to Melissa and fucks her and then the whole burgeois fortress – his family, the university, even the law a little bit – comes crashing down on him.

In retrospect, maybe it's a little shortsighted of me to juxtapose Ishmael to modern Hamlet and Chip like that. Now that I think about it, the book *does* end when Ishmael gets rescued by *The Rachel* right there in the middle of the ocean, so we don't really know what happens or what he starts to feel like when he gets back to Bourgeois Manhattan life. Probably he gets hemmed up like Chip or just hates his life like Hamlet. But BECAUSE we don't know what happens other than the fact that he eventually sits down to record the events, BECAUSE of the fact that our last vision of Ishmael is him clutching Queequeg's coffin in the middle of this vast, flowing body of water, the fantasy that starts with that opening paragraph never really ends, even if you read the whole book, which I'm not switching up and recommending you do, Jon. And so maybe Melville agrees with me that the fantasy of escape is only achievable in fiction, which is to say only in our imagination? I dunno exactly what he means, but I know that when I talk about this shit it makes me think about this one time when I felt just like Ishmael, like I'd escaped and I was floating somewhere in a calm body of water. Truth is, I wasn't anywhere near the water. I was in a musky bedroom, one of 10 or so private rooms on either side of a dark hallway right above a strip club on Walking Street in Phattya Beach, Thailand (I told you, Jon, radical honesty). I'll spare you the details of how I ended up there, but I was escorted into the room by a "lady of the night," so to speak, and we hit it off so well that even after the "transaction," so to speak, she stayed right next to me in bed, cuddling and everything, and showed me pictures of her kids and her family, and told me she learned English in Australia where she lived from 4 to 18 with her mom and a tall man she called "Marc," and that Marc owned a business in Thailand and that that's how her mom met him, and that a few days after she turned 18 her mom hurried them back to Thailand without Marc and without explaining why. We didn't really talk about much more than that. Maybe I mentioned details of my own family, but I dunno, the only thing I *really* remember is that in this strange, dangerous, transient place with a total stranger who could've been lying to me about everything, I felt so fucking calm, like as if I could stay there forever, like when you're staring ahead at nothing in particular and your body settles and your blood flow slows down and you almost get tired but its too peaceful to nod off so you stay awake staring until your phone rings or your neighbor starts playing Call of Duty. And then this weird shit happened. I started crying. Out of nowhere. She asked me why I was crying and I told her it was because Walking Street reminded me of Yager, who hung up from a ceiling fan in the barracks after our second deployment. But I wasn't crying because of Yager. I didn't even know him that well, and if I'm being really honest with you his death was kind of an inconvenience to me seeing as I was on barracks duty the night he did it and it caused a LOT of chaos. (What do you want me to tell you,

Jon? We always pretend to care about things that don't really matter so much to us. A lot of people cried about Yager, but I didn't). Hell if I know what makes me cry. Maybe I was crying next to this "lady of the night" because I knew that at some point that evening I'd have to leave. Or maybe I was crying because I knew that even if I could stay there forever, I'd eventually want to leave.

•

Jon, I really wanted to give you that awkward piece of advice before I fell asleep last night, the one I brought up kinda vaguely after telling you about Dr. Sherman's shirts. But I got too tired. More precisely, I took a ~~fistful of Benadryl~~ Melatonin and knocked out before I even started feeling woozy. So, since I'm now ~~somewhat~~ completely sober, I'm just gonna rip the band-aid off. The advice is this: you need to rethink your wardrobe. And it's not that I think you dress badly, no, what I'm saying is that you dress benignly and somewhat discordantly with the purposes of your profession…and I feel like this is one of the reasons why your literary star is fading. There used to be a time when you, not you per se, but really any author of decent repute, could dress lamely or not give much thought to the fit and still be respected as a writer, because people only saw you once every couple of years on Charlie Rose and they assumed that what you were wearing at Charlie's roundtable, usually one of those huge, square-shouldered suits, was an outfit your publicist or stylist or wife picked out for you that day and that it wasn't how you typically dressed, and so in their imaginations, which is all they had before cell phones and the internet, they thought of you as a pretty fashionable person in your private life, because this is how we generally think of writers, as stylish. But now we have these encyclopedias/roving eyes in our pockets and we can instantly collect dozens of images of how you look on TV interviews, in magazines, and also on the beach or boardwalk, or in the background of someone else's photo at a party you didn't think would be photographed, or in a tagged photo on Instagram, or at a smalltown book event that made the local news and now shows up on your Google Images search, etc. And so we form this whole aesthetic judgment of you beforehand that, believe it or not, affects whether or not we read your books and even how we read them. Because if we think of *you* a certain way, we can't help but transfer that judgment to what you *say*. Case in point: I'm not a Marxist anymore or even a very politically-engaged Feminist, and I'm actually really turned off by books that become popular TV shows, but I knew from the moment I laid eyes on Sally Rooney that, despite our political differences, I'd absolutely looove her fiction. And because I knew I'd love her fiction, I read all of it (except for *Intermezzo*, which I haven't gotten to yet) with a lot of enthusiasm and interest. And it wasn't so much her face that caught me, which is also cute to me, no, it was how she dresses. Have you seen the image of her on the bridge, the one where she's leaning on the parapet looking to her left with the black crew neck sweater tucked into that accordian-pleated viridian-toned skirt!? Bruh. 😡🤩Or the one from The New Yorker shoot with the blue-gray blazer over the lightly-crinkled eggshell poplin? Best way I can describe her personal style, like if I wrote for Vanity Fair or GQ or something like that, is this: "muted and calm, committed to being perfectly un-shocking, but still capable of generating immense aesthetic pleasure," which is just what her books feel like if you approach them with an eye to her fashion, if you take them not just as bold critiques of late capitalism and institutional oppression but also as examples of how to extract beauty from plainness, wonderment from the purely quotidian.

But obviously, logic or physics or whatever it is dictates that the "Rooney Effect" has an inverse, which I like to call the "Knausgaard Effect," which is when a writer's personal fashion is so off-putting or just blehhh that you don't wanna read them at all, or, even worse, their "look" preseasons their words with such a sourness that you reject what they say, like you look for the flaw or the lie or the disingenuous thought in every sentence, and usually you find it, and after a while you can't even go on, even if you're one of those readers like me who HAS TO finish a book once you start it. I named the Knausgaard Effect after the big Norseman Karl Ove because this guy's personal style is so self-consciously humorless and devoid of sentiment that it's really tough to take him on in good faith. If you were to look at Karl for the first time, like knowing he's an author but not knowing *what* he writes, your first assumption is that he's one of these young-ish revisionist biographers of the Third Reich, like a taller, more haggardly-looking Darryl Cooper. Your next thought is that he writes brooding, fatalistic, performatively self-loathing autofiction. Spoiler alert, Jon, he writes brooding, fatalistic, performatively self-loathing autofiction. (I know what I'm about to say doesn't prove my point exactly and may even seem kinda petty, but I can't help it, I gotta get this off my chest: there's this one pic of him on Google Images leaning against the doorway of his "personal library" with a too-tight black t-shirt, some slim fit khakis, and dirty Reeboks WITH THE LACES UN-TIED. And when I noticed his feet I'm like, "Bro, tie your fuckin' shoelaces! Not for nothing, you're an internationally best-selling author and a so-called literary phenomenon; it's not like the Washington Post photographer who's getting comp'd hand over fist to travel to your backyard bungalo somewhere in The fuckin' Fjords would've complained if you said, 'hey doll, can you lemme lace these bad boys up before we shoot?'" But then I thought, "Of couuuuuuurse he can't tie his shoelaces. The weight of existence is so goddam heavy, even for a multimillionaire 'novelist' with a cute wife and a big house and a personal library, that the effort it takes to bend over and maybe just tuck 'em into his socks might crush him").

But to be fair to Karl, he doesn't *always* wear tees and tan khakis. His preferred fit is a combination of dark solid blazer + dark solid button up or quarter zip + dark solid slacks or denim + (when he's feelin' really sexy I guess) a dark solid racer jacket, obviously in place of the dark solid blazer + don't let me forget the dark solid leather boots, all of which are usually photographed against – you guessed it, Jon – a dark solid background. All this dark solid shit is supposed to show a rejection of style and sentimentality, because that's what he wants you to see in his writing, that there're no rhetorical flourishes or flights of imagination and definitely no friendly metaphors like the one I wrote before about my dad being a Woody Allen-esque Jew, and that it's really just page after page, section after section, volume after volume of Karl hypernoticing ordinary stuff, and he wants you to believe that this is justified and innovative, that things like plot and drama and just plain ol' storytelling are "artifices" that color over the messy minutiae of human life, and that these artifices need to be eliminated or at least minimized, and that by this logic the next stage in the evolution of the novel is spending 40 pages describing the anxiety of sneaking a lingerie magazine into the bathroom and masturbating as quietly as possible so mom doesn't hear you from the next room over. And I'll admit that a once over of KOK's minimalist fashion *does* reinforce his paring down of literary style, makes it seem sensible and embodied outside of the text itself, ya know? But here's what I'm really trying to get to: if you stare at his photos long enough, if you scrutinize him the way he scrutinizes the leaves in the gutter or the dirt under his own finger nails in his books, what you eventually see is the neurosis in his eyes. And it may be subtle, but when you catch it…brother, its fuckin'

intense. In a couple of these photos he actually looks terrified, like one of those characters in *Get Out*, the ones who walk around in their own bodies but aren't *really* in there. And I just KNOW that what he's reacting to with this expression is the possibility that you might perceive the truth, which is that the clothes are wearing HIM, by which I'm saying he doesn't really accept them or believe in them like the way Sally Rooney believes in hers.

When I first peeped this, I thought I might've been crazy, or maybe that I was just reaching a bit too far, but that was before I heard him on Bella Freud's podcast where (no pun intended) he Freudian slipped by saying his black-on-black fits are his "uniform." Maybe he wasn't totally conscious of his meaning, but I'm a guy who wore a uniform, like one of the most legendary uniforms in the world, just about every single day for YEARS, so I instantly felt what was underneath this lil quip. Hear this, Jon: when I was on Parris Island back in the day, which is the place where they do Marine Corps boot camp, they set aside a whole half day for this event they call "Funeral Photos," and it's basically when you take your first photo in those famed Dress Blues, and they call it your funeral photo because it's the one they'll put right next to your casket if you get schwacked and your family gets an Arlington burial for you. But the weird thing is that this photo, the one image that people always associate with "courage" and "selflessness" and "sacrifice," was taken WEEKS before you even earned the title "Marine," and, truth be told, so many people take the photo and then don't ever become a Marine because they get injured and sent to rehab platoon or they get kicked out for "failure to adapt" because they can't remember all the stupid ditties or they just can't take the abuse so they claim suicidal for a medical discharge. And what's even weirder about the photo is that they're not actually wearing the actual Dress Blues uniform: it's a fuckin' shoulder shell, kinda like a football shoulder pad but with the chest and neck and upper shoulder part of the Dress Blues stitched on to it, and this is so they can use the same one for EVERY person in the battalion on that day 😂😂🤣🤣. And so you feel doubly cheap, because *one*, you're pretending to be a Marine before you're actually a Marine, and *two*, you're not even wearing the real uniform. That's why my face looks so stupid the way it does in my funeral photo. I have this dumb-ass exaggerated scowl, probably to compensate for not having any real reason to scowl at that moment in time seeing as to how I hadn't been in any shit up to that point. And then my eyes are looking straightforward but are also vaguely squinted, almost like I'm embarrassed to see the photographer seeing me in my costume…and not just embarrassed, but also ashamed, because I know that she knows I'm cosplaying a uniform that all these kids who joined before me wore to their last Marine Corps Ball, the one right before they got their legs blown off in Iraq. And tbh, even when I hit the fleet after boot camp, even after 3 whole deployments, I never really shook the sense that I was wearing someone else's uniform, or that the uniform was kinda wearing or mocking me. Because I was a comms guy, not a grunt, and even though I was attached to the grunts alotta the time, I wasn't a trigger puller by trade so I didn't have to do *all* the stuff they did, and even tho I've been some places and earned all my medals and ribbons, my life *was* a little bit easier than theirs on the day-to-day, like I only shit in a hole in the ground a couple 'a times in my whole career, Jon, and these guys did that ALL THE TIME, and in fact one of them had to show me how to dig the hole with my E-Tool (shovel) the first time and how deep to make it, because when you're an indoor plumbing guy your whole life, as I suspect you are, you sorta take for granted that your designated receptacle has been crafted with careful consideration for how much space we humans need below us, not to get all scatalogical on ya. So even when I took pics in my *actual* Marine Corps uniforms, like at the ball or out in the field, I'd do something ironic, like make a

funny face or throw up a gang sign, to show how I know it's ridiculous that I'm allowed to wear this thing. Or if I had to take a serious pic, like a battalion photo or a promotion pic with an older Marine who just pinned on my new rank, I'd have a really solemn, deferential expression, and it's because I was saying to any of those hard-chargers who might see the photo, mainly the guys who were in Fallujah and Marjah and places like that, that I'm truly fucking sorry they let me wear the same uniform as you.

I know I'm rambling on again, which always happens when I take my ~~brother's suboxone~~ Melatonin in the middle of a paragraph. But what I'm saying by all this, Jon, is that I'm uniquely suited to spot the lie in Karl's "look." And not to re-hash what I started to say up there 👆, but once you see that the "uniform," as he himself calls it, is wearing HIM instead of the other way around, it changes the fiction, it makes you wonder if the whole mood and outlook, just like his fashion, isn't a farce, so that when you come to the last line of Volume1of *My Struggle*, the one about death being as arbitrary an occurrence as a coat falling off its hanger, it stinks of dishonesty, because now you're persuaded that all his talk about the banality of life is just a cover or an overcompensation like that ugly scowl in my funeral photo, that all that shit at the end of *My Struggle* about humans being just "one form among many which the world reproduces over and over," no different than the coat hanger or the fallen coat or the lamp in his dead dad's bedroom, is the *opposite* of what he really believes deep down, and that maybe, *just maybe*, if he had the right outfit he could dredge up from the depths of his unconscious something mystical and wonderful and believable and so stunningly *un*-banal, like this:

> *Maybe we're just born to love and worry about the people we know, and to go on loving and worrying even when there are more important things we should be doing. ...Because when we should have been reorganising the distribution of the world's resources and transitioning collectively to a sustainable economic model, we were worrying about sex and friendship instead. Because we loved each other too much and found each other too interesting. And I love that about humanity, and in fact it's the very reason I root for us to survive - because we are so stupid about each other.*

Fuckin' Sally….□□

Aright, so now that we possess a shared understanding of the complex intersection of fashion and fiction, let's get back to you, Jon. The whole reason why I brought up Dr. Sherman in the first place is because when I saw your array of photos on Google Images and began to kinda scrutinize your fashion, he's the first person who came to my mind, and it's because you dress just like him, which is to say you dress nicely and neatly and appear confident in those well-fitting earth-toned plaids and blue-grey button ups and the occasional top sweater, and that you give the impression of someone who is, if not acutely intrigued by fashion, at least ambiently aware of our modern sensibilities in this realm. But all of which is *also* to say that you dress like an academic, and not like a novelist. And this is a problem, because as I've tried to imply through the preceding examples of Sally Rooney and Karl Ove, discordances between the way you dress and the way you think often transfer to the text as ruptures which undermine the reader's confidence in the integrity of your imagined realities. It's true that academics, especially in the humanities, have specializations and in some cases even very hyper-specific interests, but

it's a fact of their shared identity as higher educators that, above all this, they pledge a kind of unspoken commitment to impartiality and rigor and objectivity, within a slightly nuanced liberal consensus framework of course, that, by way of example, justifies the use of a 2,000-page critical reader with Harold Bloom on one page and Judith Butler on the next, a chapter on Plato here and a handful essays by Foucault over there, and so on and so forth. And thus their workplace fashion necessarily indicates the same overarching commitment to a basic general style with occasional and slight variations in detail – e.g. the recurring plaids with infrequent, though unshocking, changes in size patterns or colors that both you and Dr. Sherman featured recently. (As an aside, did you see what I was doing there? Did you get it, Jon? I was mimicking the rigidity of academic jargon in a kind of metatextual flourish 😆). But seriously, Jon, you can't be out here posing as an academic – you're a novelist for Chrissake, and that's really all you are, I hate to tell you. But that's a wonderful thing because it means you don't have to be plain and inoffensive and only "slightly varied" on the day-to-day. You get to be unwieldy and curious and mostly unpredictable, and you get to be biased about something on Monday and then embody the opposite bias on Tuesday, and you can be complex and contradict yourself and show ambivalence about things you're supposed to feel passionate about. And yes of course you need to have a Northstar, even if your Northstar is something very basic (because you can't be deracinated like DeLulu and Guttari), but it doesn't have to matter all that much how you navigate towards your Northstar. But, Jon, trust me, your fashion HAS TO reflect this, because if it doesn't, then some people, the ones who mine the Google Images before they read your novel, won't see your work as free and inventive and magical, they'll just say its lazy and unstructured and that your content got away from you, and they'll write things on Goodreads like "it seems like he's flying the plane while he's building it" because they'll mistake you for someone who actually cares about that distinction. Man, I'm tired af…and I gotta ~~get plastered again~~ wind down before bed. So here's what I want you to do, Jon. I want you to look into Adam Friedland. I'm assuming you know who he is, but if you don't, he's this really funny and sensitive and pleasantly self-deprecating comedian and talk show host and most importantly a fashion icon to millennial and zoomer audiences. And what you'll notice about his fashion, and the reason why I'm recommending him to you, is that he has a novelist's touch, so to speak. I mean, he's got this slight, lithe frame (which you don't have, but we can work around it) that lets him shape shift like a magical realist or one of those post-modern stylists, so that on one day he's slouching and moving around languidly inside of an oversized graphic tee and the next he's almost sporting a different, more fortified body under a vintage tailored blue blazer with the gold naval buttons. But even when he steps it up with the blue blazer for the really important guests like Ro Khana or Lina Khan or William Macy, he always has a Northstar, which is this commitment to a certain degree of controlled, carefully-attenuated messiness. Anyway, I'm exhausted, so just check him out: https://www.adamfriedland.com/

•

When I decided to write to you in the first place, Jon, I told myself I wouldn't change or erase anything that made it to the page, that I would just put it all out there and let you decide if I'm the kinda guy you'd invite to Thanksgiving dinner. But I'm REALLY tempted to delete that whole bit from yesterday about your's and Karl's and Sally's and Adam's and Dr. Sherman's clothes, because I just re-read it…and now that I'm dried up from the ~~Suboxone~~ Melatonin it sounds so opinionated and judgey and so fuckin' *certain*. (I get like that with a lotta ~~downers~~

Melatonin in me, or so I'm told. One time I woke up from a ~~fuckinnn bender~~ nap, and I guess I took so much ~~whatever~~ Melatonin beforehand that I didn't realize I went into this whole lengthy spiel about the corruption of the Federal Reserve while I was ~~high af~~ dozing off, and I wouldn't've known I was talkin' like that but my Melatonin supplier thought it was hilarious and recorded me on his iphone, and when he played it for me it was like listening to a different person – like someone with actual knowledge or beliefs! – and the only explanation I can think of is that I was somnolently recalling something I'd heard on a YouTube video or a podcast). Anyway, my point is that if people should know anything about me when they first meet me, so as not to be let down later on in the relationship, yourself especially, it's that I'm not certain about much of anything, that I don't really have very strong stances or convictions about things, which I'm sad to say is not such an easy way to be in our world these days. I dunno, maybe I'm like this cuz I've always been kind of a mid-century fanatic, which was a time when a lot of books and movies promoted this sexy archetype of the "man about the world" – he was mysterious and usually a bit weathered in a handsome way and just casually uncommitted and always moving around because he wasn't tethered too tightly to places or people or ideas or political revolutions or any of that stuff, and as I'm saying this you're probably thinking of James Bond, but you'd be wrong cuz Bond's more of a Cold War anti-hero, because even though he has some of the aesthetics of the "man about the world" – the clothes, the nonchalance, the peripateticness – he really boils down to being a pretty ardent capitalist and technocrat and imperialist and, above all else, a British Nationalist. No, by far the best example of what I'm saying is a man named Mr. Brown from this really dark and terrifying and surprisingly little-known Graham Greene novel called *The Comedians*. I won't bore you with the deets if you haven't read it, but it's basically the story of these three guys, an American, a Brit, and a Monte Carlo-an, who travel to Haiti on a ship called *The Medea*, all for different reasons, right after Papa Doc Duvalier takes over the country and his secret police are schwacking people left and right for their political dissidence. One of the three, Mr. Brown, the Monte Carlo-an, owns a hotel out there (duh, a kinda too-obvious symbol for "transience" and political avoidance), and he's there to try to sell it because the violence and political instability have made it totally unviable. Well, that's his ostensible reason for being there; he's also out there because he's hittin' this beautiful woman who's married to some South American Ambassador to Haiti, but the tension is that the Ambassador's wife won't leave her husband for Brown mostly because Brown is rootless and ideologically vague and would never join the counter-revolution. But part of my reason for bringing this up is to show you this great line Brown has, which kinda romanticizes how I feel (or don't feel) about politics and religion and stances and causes. It's so good I'm gonna block quote it so you can read the whole thing, Jon. So Brown goes:

> *...there is an advantage in being born..without roots, for one accepts more easily what comes. The rootless have experienced, like all the others, the temptation of sharing the security of a religious creed or a political faith, and for some reason we have turned the temptation down. We are the faithless; we admire the dedicated, the Doctor Magiots* (this communist guy who dies for the counter-revolution) *and the Mr. Smiths* (a vegetarian who wants to spread vegetarianism in Haiti to calm everyone down) *for their courage and their Integrity, for their fidelity to a cause, but through timidity, or through lack of sufficient zest, we find ourselves the only ones truly committed - committed to the whole world of evil and of good, to the wise and to the foolish, to the indifferent and to the mistaken.*

> *We have chosen nothing except to go on living, "rolled around on Earth's diurnal course, With rocks and stones and trees."*

I realize after typing that out that it sounds a little like nihilism, this whole thing about choosing "nothing but to go on living," but you have to read the whole book to know this isn't exactly what Brown chooses, and I suppose maybe he's being a little hysterical and slightly overstating his point in the heat of the moment. And you also have to understand what kinda person Brown is on a day-to-day basis if you really wanna feel the full force of this message. What I mean is this guy could get away with all manner of abuse and philandering and theft and exploitation and whatnot and nobody would even suspect him of it or probably even care very much if they did….but instead of being that way, he's more like an Uncle Jesse: kind of edgy and arrogant and a little acerbic at times, but also a tender lover and a polite and fair boss and a superb host to his one lodger at the hotel and even a friend to the man who's rizzin' up his girl at the end of the story, so that by the last chapter, even tho it's *another* one of the main characters who dies heroically for the counter-revolution (while Brown abstains), it kinda feels like Brown is the hero. And I think it's because he's the one who faces the "whole world of evil" without any "religious creed" or "political faith" and remains, if not pure, at least pretty harmless. And so it's almost like Graham Greene is saying that, yes, we need activists and revolutionaries and believers and proselytizers for the heavy lifting and to prevent our descent into fascism, etc., but there'll never be enough of them to cover *all* of us in their zeal and passion and righteousness, and so we also need a kind of civilian faith, a sort of baseline pact not to harm one another, no matter how bad things get, and maybe that's just called regular 'ol decency.

But these very deliberate Mr. Brown types are goin' outta style fast, so my faithless ass is kinda naked in the cold with fewer and fewer "men about the world" to run cover for me. I'd be lying if I said this isn't a small part of why I reached out to *you* specifically, Jon, because these ideas about faithlessness and political avoidance matter to me and I feel like you understand them well and won't judge me for believing in them to some degree, and I also feel like even tho your style isn't to write about these mysterious and cavalier jetsetters with no religion or politics, a lot of your stuff (or the little amount of it that I've read) is, just like Mr. Brown says, "committed to the whole world of evil and good, to the wise and to to the foolish, etcetera," because isn't it part of your project to paint the whole canvas of the family, to really emphasize its ridiculousness and messiness and even its traumas and micro-traumas down to a molecular level, like to show how really mistaken and foolish and narrow minded and behind-the-times and unprogressive someone like Enid from *The Corrections* can be, but then to decide NOT to hate her for this the way her disgraced critical theorist of a son sometimes does (at least through the first 60 pages 😬)? Ya know, before I wrote to you, I thought about writing to someone else in your cohort…it was Zadie 😍😍. But then I decided if I did that I'd have to leave out all the toilet humor and the stuff about the prostitutes and all the references to Tinder and whatnot, and above all else I just wanted to be as honest and uncensored as possible with someone, and I just knew I couldn't be that way with Zadie because frankly I'm kind of in love with her. But anyway, the main reason why I considered her is because I had just read *Swing Time* a few weeks before I sat down to write this…and I couldn't get the last page of that novel out of my mind. Maybe you don't remember the details, so for clarity's sake what happens is this: the unnamed narrator, who's also the main character, has just lost her mom, who was some sort of progressive British parliamentarian before she got sick with cancer, and right before she dies the mom tells the

narrator to take care of Tracy, who's the narrator's childhood best friend, and Tracy's young babies, who are kinda up shit's creek financially and just have a rough life with no dad in the household and with Tracy being a textbook borderline or bipolar, and it's a bit of a strange last request because the narrator and Tracy have grown really far apart over the course of the novel, and recently Tracy has been very mean to the narrator and her sick mom, sending harassing emails and making up lies about the narrator's dad's sexual proclivities and even posting an embarrassing childhood video of the narrator to the web. And so the narrator is walking to Tracy's house to make good on her mom's dying request, and then she thinks better of her decision and starts to turn around because not only has Tracy been mean lately but the narrator also realizes that making Tracy's family her own like her mom wants her to do is just a grief-clouded fantasy. But then she keeps walking towards Tracy's place because she has this other thought. She thinks: "there might be something else I could offer, something simpler, more honest, between my mother's idea of salvation and nothing at all." And what she's talking about is that idea of a "civilian faith" I mentioned up there 👆, a way of regarding other people that falls between *political* salvation on the one end, which just means imposing your political ethics on another person for the ostensible good of the whole, and withdrawing from the "world of evil and of good" altogether on the other end. And it's no coincidence that just as this thought occurs to her she sees Tracy on her terrace, this woman who the narrator could so easily hate if she wanted to, "in a dressing gown and slippers, her hands in the air, turning, her children around her, everybody dancing," and that's the last line of the novel, and the reason why the image is so arresting is because it's just goodness and beauty and love without any political pretense whatsoever 😟😟😟😟.

While we're on this subject, you wanna know what's the worst thing a woman, or probably any person for that matter, has ever said to me, Jon? This beautiful woman who I was slowly falling for and thought was falling for me told me, right before she ripped the proverbial band-aid off and ended things, that "Principles ARE personality, so unfortunately you have neither," the "you" being me in this case of course. Here's why she said it, if you're interested. If not, feel free to skip this paragraph, because this is a lot and not really all that important. (Hold; lemme grab a Melatonin real quick too). Ok, back. So, approx. this time last year, I matched with this woman who happened to be a pretty well-known journalist and writer, and she even interviewed Joe Biden once (or maybe it was Joe Budden? Either way, an achievement), and even though she's a midwesterer and I live in Amboy we matched because she happened to be in NYC doing a book event for something she just published, a memoir about her divorce and also a really scathing commentary on the patriarchy, which I later found in Barnes & Noble and saw that it was an NYT best-seller. Anyway, we hit it off soooo well. Whenever I match with someone who's a reader or a writer, I always send them the same flirty lil opening line…I'll be like, "I don't send nudes, but I do send bookshelf photos," and then I usually send them a picture of a relatively innocuous portion of my bookshelf. And she loved that, and like I said we hit it off really well, and so we talked about books and her writing career for an hour or two that first night, and then we had Zoom dates every day for the next week because she had to go back to the midwest for some stuff before returning to NYC the following month, and my favorite date of them all was when we synced up our iPads and watched *Good Will Hunting* together on Zoom…and I had her dying laughing because I went word-for-word with Will and Chuckie during that famous Harvard bar scene, Southie accent 'n all. She probably thought I was "wicked smaaaht" after that. But then the next day we were talking on the phone and she asked me a question that I

figured she should've asked earlier if she cared so much about it. What she asked was if I had any MAGA friends, like totally outta nowhere she asked this, and I said I didn't, at least not among my close friends here in Jersey, at least not to my knowledge. And then because I just always keep talking for no reason, I started jabbering about my friend BryanCruz (Yes, we say his full name like it's one word, because we have another friend named Bryan Alvarado, who we call "BryanAlva"). And basically I told her that BryanCruz (hereinafter Bryan) wrote a note to his daughter's elementary school about some lesson he didn't agree with (and I'm not gonna say what the lesson was because then you might think I'm saying I don't agree with the lesson either, which is not the case), and I even said that his reason for writing the letter was that the lesson interfered with his daughter's speech therapy for her lisp and not that he's some sort of sexist or phobic ideologue! But she didn't buy it and then she said this crazy thing. She said, "I have to be suspicious of men whose friends want *my* friends to die," and I'm sure what she meant was that some of her friends were implicated, albeit abstractly, in the lesson that Bryan opposed on the grounds of his daughter's speech therapy, but I didn't understand how this equated to him wanting anyone to die, so I simply said, "Bryan doesn't want anybody to die," and then she said, "You can't possibly know that," and then I said, "Of course I know that," and she said, "Well, how do you know?" and that's when I said this: "...because he drives all the way to Garside Ave. in North Newark on Sundays to bring his 90-year old Pipa her groceries, and because he dressed up as Flounder for his daughter's Little Mermaid birthday party this year…and because when we were 13 and got jumped by some Bloods on Craig St. and BryanAlva and the other guy with us took off, Bryan stayed, even tho he was the fastest one outta all of us and could've gotten away clean…and I would've known someone pulled out a boxcutter if I wasn't getting trampled by feet, but I couldn't see and so I didn't know until it was over and Bryan's forearm skin was floppin' around…and maybe it would've been even worse if someone didn't step out onto their front porch with their corded phone stretched to its absolute furthest limit yelling real loud that the police were on the line." And you know what my lovely interlocutor said after all of that? She said, "That has nothing to do with his politics," and all I could think to say in reply was, "That's my point."

•

Well, Jon, I've tried to end and send this thing four times already, and every time I try to wrap it up I think of one more thing to say to you, and the crazy thing is I actually have, like, two more really interesting ideas I wanna share with you that I'm gonna force myself to hold off on until your reply. And what's so weird to me is that I'm not usually like this…like, in all the letters to Joshua Cohen and Zizek and Andrea Long Chu and Halle Butler and Cornell West and Bella Freud and Lana Del Ray's publicist and Caroline Polachek, I would feel pretty content after a page or 2 and just send it off (which is why I was actually very surprised by the cease-and-desist from Cohen's lawyer…I mean, you would think someone of his voluminous literary production could handle a dozen or so two-pagers). But with you I feel this need to keep talking. I guess that's what happens when you just vibe with someone right away. I dunno, the way I see it, what else is there to do but talk to each other? Between Carmen at my job and the names I just mentioned and now you, I guess I'm always talking to someone…and I feel like if I stop talking, I might stop breathing.

Anyway, I've said so much about me and haven't really asked you much…so, what kind of music do you like?

Very sincerely,

Evan Weiss